

Translation Handbook

دليل الترجمة



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A beginner's guide to translating between English and Arabic

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مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

First edition, 2026

Translation Handbook: A Beginner's Guide to Translating between English and Arabic

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Preface

The Translation Team of the Guild Professional Club prepared this handbook for students taking their first steps in translation between English and Arabic. Use it in workshops or on your own.

By the end of it, you should:

- know the basic rules and principles of translation;
- understand the main **differences** between English and Arabic;
- recognise the main **difficulties** that translators meet;
- be able to use practical **strategies and techniques** to solve them;
- be able to check your own work and explain your choices.

The Translation Team

Acknowledgements

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How to use this handbook

From easy to hard

Each part builds on the one before it, so read the parts in order:

1. **Part 1: Getting started.** What translation is, preparation, and how English and Arabic differ.
2. **Part 2: Understanding meaning.** Form and meaning, types of meaning, and context.
3. **Part 3: Words that go together.** Collocations, idioms and proverbs.
4. **Part 4: Methods and techniques.** Equivalence, literal and free translation, metaphors, procedures and strategies.
5. **Part 5: Culture and new words.** Cultural approximation, descriptive translation and lexical creation.
6. **Part 6: Working with whole texts.** Text analysis, text types and point of view.
7. **Part 7: Tools and resources.** Dictionaries, terminology, and machine translation and AI.
8. **Part 8: Checking and explaining.** Revision, risk assessment and commentary.
9. **Part 9: Audiovisual translation.** Types and challenges of AVT, and subtitling.

At the end you will find a glossary of all key terms and the references.

How each chapter works

1. **Introduction:** what the chapter covers.
2. **Key terms:** new words, with Arabic equivalents and short definitions (also in the glossary).
3. **Explanation and examples** in both languages.
4. **Try it:** a few questions, with the answers straight after.
5. **Remember:** the main points.

Signs used in this handbook

- **EN → AR**: translating from English into Arabic. **AR → EN**: translating from Arabic into English.
- ✓ marks a good translation and ✗ a poor one.
- Words in **bold** are key terms.

Sources

Published sources are cited in the text, for example (Newmark, 1988), and listed in full in the References. Other examples come from the team's course materials (Translation Team, n.d.) or were written for this handbook.

Abbreviations

- **AI**: artificial intelligence (الذكاء الاصطناعي)
- **AR → EN**: from Arabic into English
- **AVT**: audiovisual translation (الترجمة السمعية البصرية)
- **EN → AR**: from English into Arabic
- **MSA**: Modern Standard Arabic (الفصحى المعاصرة)
- **MT**: machine translation (الترجمة الآلية)
- **SL**: source language (اللغة المصدر); **SLC**: source language culture (ثقافة اللغة المصدر)
- **ST**: source text (النص المصدر)
- **TL**: target language (اللغة الهدف); **TLC**: target language culture (ثقافة اللغة الهدف)
- **TS**: Translation Studies (دراسات الترجمة)
- **TT**: target text (النص الهدف)

Part 1: Getting started

Chapter 1: Translation and the translator

In this chapter. What translation is, its main types, and what a good translator needs.

KEY TERMS

- **Translation** (الترجمة): Transferring meaning from one language into another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting.
- **Interpreting** (الترجمة الشفهية): Transferring spoken language into another language.
- **Source text (ST)** (النص المصدر): The original text that you translate.
- **Target text (TT)** (النص الهدف): Your translation.
- **Approximation** (التقريب): Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible.
- **Commissioned translator** (مترجم بتكليف): A translator who translates a text at someone else's request.
- **Self-initiated translator** (مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية): A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative.

What is translation?

Imagine a friend who only speaks Arabic asks what an English sign says. You would not read out the words one by one; you would say what the sign **means**, in good Arabic. That is translation.

The team's course materials define translation as "an activity or process of transferring textual meaning from one language to another" (Translation Team, n.d.). Another definition is "rendering the meaning of a text into another language in the way that the author intended the text" (Newmark, 1988, p. 5).

So a translator carries **meaning**, not words. English speakers say *Break a leg!* to wish someone good luck, especially before a performance:

Word by word: اكسر ساقاً ✗ By meaning: بالتوفيق ✓

Translation is approximation

No two languages match perfectly, so a translation is never an exact copy. It is an **approximation**, especially of cultural meaning (Chapter 14). Translation has been described as “saying almost the same thing” (Eco, 2003).

Translation is communication

You receive the message in one language and pass it on in the other. If your reader does not understand it, the translation has not worked.

Types of translation

- **Written translation:** translating written texts, the subject of this handbook.
- **Interpreting:** translating speech, while the speaker is talking (simultaneous) or after the speaker stops (consecutive).
- **Sight translation:** reading a written text aloud in another language.
- **Audiovisual translation**, such as subtitling and dubbing: translating films, television and video games within limits of time and space (Part 9).
- **Localisation:** adapting a product, such as a website or an app, to another country’s language and culture.

In a wider sense, there are three kinds of translation (Jakobson, 1959): rewording within one language (**intra lingual**), translating from one language into another (**inter lingual**, the subject of this handbook), and turning words into another medium, such as a film or a painting (**inter semiotic**).

What does a good translator need?

The course materials name two main characteristics: **bilingual knowledge** and, equally important, **cultural knowledge**. In practice, a good translator:

- is fluent in both languages;
- is **bicultural** (مُلمّ بالثقافتين): knows both cultures well;
- has wide general knowledge, like a “walking encyclopedia”, and learns about the topic of each text;

- has a rich **linguistic repertoire** (الحصيلة اللغوية), including idioms and fixed expressions;
- gains experience through practice and revision.

The same idea appears in Arabic writing more than a thousand years ago: a translator must know both languages equally well (al-Jāhiz, 1965):

ولا بدّ للترجمان من أن يكونَ بياؤه في نفس الترجمة في وزنِ علمه في نفس المعرفة،
وينبغي أن يكونَ أعلمَ الناسَ باللغة المنقولة والمنقولِ إليها، حتى يكونَ فيهما سواءٌ
وغايةً.

A translator is a reader before being a writer: first understand the source text fully, then write it again in the target language.

Four common myths

- “**Anyone who speaks two languages can translate.**” Translation also needs training, practice and knowledge of the subject.
- “**Translation is exchanging words.**” A translator carries the meaning, not the words.
- “**Machines will replace translators.**” Machine translation gives drafts; people still check and finish them (Chapter 22).
- “**A translator can translate any subject.**” Most translators specialise in one or two fields, such as law or medicine.

Two kinds of translator

The difference is who chooses the text. A **commissioned translator** translates a text that someone else has asked for, such as a client, an agency or an employer, and follows the client's brief and requirements (Chapter 2). A **self-initiated translator** chooses the text, such as a poem they love, and makes their own choices.

Both freelance and in-house translators do commissioned work, and any translator can also translate a text on their own initiative.

Try it

1. What is the difference between translation and interpreting?
2. A publisher asks you to translate a novel. Are you a commissioned or a self-initiated translator?
3. Why is translation called “approximation”?

Answers

1. Translation deals with written texts; interpreting deals with speech.
2. Commissioned: the publisher chose the text and asked you to translate it.
3. Because no two languages match perfectly, so the translator can only come as close as possible to the original meaning.

REMEMBER

- Translation carries **meaning**, not words, from one language to another.
- A good translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Commissioned translators follow the brief; self-initiated translators choose their own texts.

Chapter 2: Tips, advice and preparation

In this chapter. How to prepare a translation: the questions to ask, the steps to follow, good habits and one worked example.

KEY TERMS

- **Client** (العميل): The person or organisation that asks for a translation.
- **Communicative purpose** (الغرض التواصلي): What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain.
- **Target audience** (الجمهور المستهدف): The people who will read the translation.
- **Translation brief** (موجز الترجمة): The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements.
- **Mental draft** (المسودة الذهنية): A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text.

Ask three questions

A news report for experts and a leaflet for children need different words. The purpose of a translation decides how it should be translated (Nord, 1997). This idea is called **skopos theory** (Chapter 26). So before you start, ask:

1. **Who is the client?** (من هو العميل؟) Clients have their own style and rules.
2. **What is the communicative purpose?** (ما الغرض التواصلي؟) To inform, to persuade, to instruct or to entertain?
3. **Who is the target audience?** (من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟) Experts or the general public? Adults or children?

The answers are your **translation brief**. If nobody gives you one, ask the client. If you chose the text yourself, answer the questions yourself.

For example, a short news report translated for KUNA, the Kuwait News Agency, informs English readers interested in Kuwait. So the translation should be formal and neutral, with a short headline.

Prepare in five steps

1. **Read the whole text** once, just to understand it. Each new reading brings new ideas.
2. **Read it again with a pen.** Highlight difficult words, idioms, names and numbers.
3. **Research** the topic if you do not know it well.
4. **List the key terms** and check them (Chapters 20 and 21).
5. **Form a mental draft:** picture how the translation should sound, and decide whether you need more resources.

Work from the whole to the parts

Break a long text down: paragraphs into sentences, sentences into phrases, phrases into words. Work out the meaning of each part, then rebuild it in the target language. Keep the links between sentences, such as cause and effect.

Tips from experienced translators

- **Be faithful** (الأمانة): do not add or remove meaning. Aim to be faithful, accurate and acceptable to the reader.
- **Remember that translation is rewriting:** the result should usually read as if it had been written in the target language.
- **Tread carefully:** translation is like a minefield (الترجمة كحقل ألغام). Know what is appropriate in both cultures.
- **Informative texts are stricter than poetry:** poetry often needs more creative freedom.
- **Keep titles short,** and do not add information to titles and headlines.
- **Translate everything,** including captions and notes.
- **Always revise,** even your best translation (Chapter 23).
- **Keep it simple.**
- **Protect your reputation:** combine quality and speed.

Putting it together: your first translation

Here is the whole process on one short sentence:

It's raining cats and dogs, so the match has been cancelled.

1. **Prepare** (this chapter). A school is informing Arabic-speaking parents about the match, so the Arabic should be clear and simple.
2. **Understand** (Chapters 4 to 8). *Raining cats and dogs* is an idiom meaning “raining heavily”. It has nothing to do with animals.
3. **Translate** (Chapters 9 to 16). A word-by-word version, إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً، لذلك تمّ إلغاء المباراة، makes no sense. A translation of the meaning works: ألغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة.
4. **Check** (Chapters 23 and 24). Read the Arabic without the English: the meaning is complete and the sentence sounds natural.
5. **Explain** (Chapter 25). “The idiom was translated by its meaning, because a word-for-word version would make no sense to Arabic-speaking readers.”

Try it

1. A hospital asks you to translate a medicine leaflet for its patients. Who is the target audience, and what style should you use?
2. What is the purpose of an advert?
3. Why should you read the whole text before you start translating?

Answers

1. Patients from the general public, so use a clear, simple style with exact words.
2. To persuade.
3. To understand it, find the difficult parts in advance, and form a mental draft.

REMEMBER

- Ask three questions first: **client, purpose, audience.**
- Read the whole text at least twice before you translate.
- Be faithful, write naturally, and always revise.

Chapter 3: English and Arabic: key differences

In this chapter. The main differences between English and Arabic (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999; Ghazala, 2008).

KEY TERMS

- **Word order** (ترتيب الكلمات): The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence.
- **Verbal sentence** (الجملة الفعلية): A sentence that starts with a verb.
- **Register** (المستوى اللغوي): How formal or informal the language is.
- **Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)** (الفصحى المعاصرة): The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.
- **Dialect** (اللهجة العامية): The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region.

Word order: verb first or subject first?

English usually puts the subject first (Subject–Verb–Object). Formal Arabic often starts with the verb (Verb–Subject–Object), although starting with the subject is also correct. So when you translate into Arabic, a verbal sentence often sounds more natural:

Sam ate the cake. → أكلَ سامٌ الكعكة (correct, but less usual) ✓

The government announced new measures. → أعلنت الحكومة إجراءاتٍ جديدة

Sentence length and linking

English writing often prefers shorter sentences. Arabic often joins several ideas in one long sentence with *و*, *ف* and *ثمّ*. So join short sentences when you translate into Arabic, and split long ones when you translate into English.

Linking words help your Arabic flow: *غير أنّ* (however), *لذلك* (therefore), *بالإضافة* (in addition), *على سبيل المثال* (for example).

Synonyms

Arabic often places two synonyms side by side for emphasis; English does this much less often. So *شجاعٌ مغوارٌ* becomes *very brave*, not *brave and daring*.

The verb “to be”

In the present tense, English needs *is* and *are*; Arabic normally leaves them out:

Translation is a fascinating field → الترجمةُ مجالٌ شائق. In formal writing, تُعدّ (“is considered”) is also possible when the sentence gives an opinion: تُعدّ الترجمةُ مجالاً شائقاً. Into English, add the verb: الطالب في المكتبة → *The student is in the library*.

Do not translate *is*, *am* or *are* with يكون: *She is kind* → إنها طيبة, not هي تكون طيبة; *I am leaving now* → سأغادر الآن. In the past, use كان: *The child was sick* → كان الطفل مريضاً.

The verbs “do” and “have”

- In negatives and questions, *do* has no Arabic word of its own: *Do not touch it* → لا تلمسه; *She did not eat* → لم تأكل; *Do you want to play?* → هل تريد أن تلعب؟
- As a main verb, *do* has a meaning: *I will do my best* → سأبذل قصارى جهدي.
- The meaning of *have* depends on its object: *She had a nice holiday* → قضت عطلةً جميلة; *She takes her pills on time* → تتناول دواءها في موعده; *She has money* → تملك مالاً.

Gender and numbers

Each language chooses what its grammar must show, such as gender and number (Baker, 2018).

- English *you* can be أنتَ (one man), أنتِ (one woman), أنتما (two people), أنتم (men or a mixed group) or أنتنَ (women). Arabic must show gender and number; English need not. In other words, “languages differ essentially in what they must convey and not in what they may convey” (Jakobson, 1959, p. 236).

- With the numbers 3 to 10, the number takes the opposite gender to the singular noun: ثلاث طالبات but ثلاثة طلاب.
- Arabic has a dual (طالبان, two students); English uses *two*.
- English *I* and *you* do not show gender, but Arabic verbs and adjectives do: *I am a student* → أنا طالبة or أنا طالب. If the sentence does not say, look for clues in the whole text: a name, a title such as *Mr* or *Mrs*, a word such as *husband* or *wife*.
- Some feminine job titles have another meaning (نائبة can mean “calamity”; قاضية can mean “fatal”), so some writers avoid them. Today, however, قاضية and نائبة are widely used for women judges and members of parliament.

Small words, big traps

Some short English words must not be translated with their first dictionary meaning:

- *He is in bed.* → إنه في فراشه or, depending on context, إنه نائم (rather than إنه (في السرير
- *As an officer, I...* → ...بصفتي ضابطاً; *As the manager of the company, I...* → ...بصفتي مدير الشركة (here *as* means a role, not ك)
- *Shops stay open.* → تظل المحلات التجارية مفتوحة (stay means “remain”, not “live”)
- *Eventually* → في نهاية المطاف (it means “in the end”, not “possibly”)
- *...to see the Roman ruins* → لزيارة الآثار الرومانية (Arabic prefers “visit”)

Punctuation

Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: the Arabic comma , , semicolon ؛ and question mark ؟.

Which Arabic?

- **Classical Arabic** (العربية الفصحى التراثية): the Arabic of the Qur'an and classical poetry.
- **Modern Standard Arabic**: the Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. Use it for written translation.
- **Dialects** (اللهجات العامية): everyday spoken Arabic. Use one only if the client asks, for example in dubbing a cartoon or a series.

Four common challenges

Most problems fall into four groups: **grammar** (النحو), **word choice** (اختيار), **punctuation and style** (including **register**: how formal the language should be), and **general or technical texts**.

Try it

1. Rewrite as a verbal sentence: الطلاب حضروا المحاضرة.
2. Translate: الطالب في المكتبة.
3. Translate: *He is in bed*.

Answers

1. حضر الطلابُ المحاضرةَ.
2. *The student is in the library.*
3. إنه نائم. or, if the context shows he is asleep, إنه في فراشه.

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR**: prefer a verbal sentence, never translate *is* with يكون, join short sentences, use Arabic punctuation.
- **AR → EN**: start with the subject, split long sentences, keep one of two synonyms, add "is".
- Use Modern Standard Arabic unless the client asks for a dialect.

Part 2: Understanding meaning

Chapter 4: Form and meaning

In this chapter. The rule that lets you change a sentence's structure safely: meaning comes before form.

KEY TERMS

- **Form** (الشكل): The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text.
- **Meaning** (المعنى): The idea that a form expresses.

The golden rule

Behind every form there is a meaning. In translation we favour meaning over form (المعنى أهم من الشكل): you may change the form, but never the meaning.

Anything said in one language can be said in another, unless the form itself is part of the message, as in a poem's rhyme (Nida & Taber, 1969).

Changing the form

Forms differ between languages, so you may change them. For example, a noun can become a verb:

- *He is a heavy smoker.* → يدخن بشراهة (the noun *smoker* becomes the verb يدخن, and the adjective *heavy* becomes بشراهة)
- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل (the noun *arrival* becomes a verb; see Chapter 12)

When the image does not travel

The British press called Tony Blair *Bush's poodle*: someone who obediently follows George Bush. A poodle has no such meaning in Arabic, so the translator keeps the meaning and changes the form: بلير، المنقاد لبوش or بلير، تابع بوش.

Try it

1. Translate by changing the form: *He is a fast runner.*
2. Translate by changing the form: *His arrival was late.*

Answers

1. يركض بسرعة.
2. وصل متأخراً.

REMEMBER

- Meaning comes before form.
- You may change the structure, but never the meaning.

Chapter 5: Types of meaning

In this chapter. The layers of meaning: a word's basic meaning, the feelings it carries, and what a speaker really means.

KEY TERMS

- **Denotation** (المعنى المعجمي): The basic, dictionary meaning of a word.
- **Connotation** (المعنى الإيحائي): The extra feeling or association a word carries.
- **Sentence meaning** (معنى الجملة): What the words of a sentence say.
- **Speaker meaning** (مقصد المتكلم): What the speaker really means by saying it.
- **Lexical gap** (الفجوة المعجمية): A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other.

Denotation and connotation

Words can share the same **denotation** but carry a different **connotation**, sometimes called propositional and expressive meaning (Baker, 2018). Choose the word with the right feeling as well as the right meaning:

- *die* (مات) is neutral; *pass away* (تُوفِّي) is polite and respectful; *kick the bucket* is informal and humorous.
- *steed* (جواد) suggests a fine, noble horse; *horse* (حصان) is neutral.
- *friend* (صديق) is general; *comrade* (رفيق) suggests a member of the same party or cause.
- *slim* (رشيق) is positive; *skinny* (هزيل) is negative.

Sentence meaning and speaker meaning

أَشْعُرُ بِالْحَرِّ states a fact, but the speaker may mean "Please turn on the air conditioning". أَصْبَحَ الْجَوُّ بَارِدًا may mean "Please turn it off", and *It's freezing in here* may mean "Please close the window".

Translate what the speaker means, in a way that sounds natural in the target language.

Problems with single words

Some problems appear at the level of the single word (Baker, 2018):

- **No equivalent word** (a lexical gap): English has *orphan* and *widow*, but no single word for *تُكَلَّى*, a mother who has lost a child. Give the meaning: *a bereaved mother*.
- **A false equivalent**: *الهنود الحمر* is neutral in Arabic, but *Red Indians* is offensive in English. Use *Native Americans*.
- **A rare word**: *شبر* has an exact English equivalent, *span*, but few readers know it. Use a familiar measure: *about 20 centimetres*.
- **Several meanings**: *خط* can be *a line*, *handwriting*, *a font* or *a route*. Let the context decide (Chapter 6).

Try it

1. In an obituary, which is better: *مات* or *تُؤَفِّي*?
2. What might a guest mean by saying *It's rather warm in here*?

Answers

1. *تُؤَفِّي*, because it is respectful.
2. A polite request to open a window or turn on the air conditioning.

REMEMBER

- Check the **connotation** of a word, not only its dictionary meaning.
- Translate what the speaker means, not only what the sentence says.

Chapter 6: Context

In this chapter. What context is, and how it tells you which meaning of a word is right.

KEY TERMS

- **Context** (السياق): Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation.
- **Micro context (co-text)** ((الداخلي) السياق اللغوي): The words and sentences immediately around a word.
- **Macro context** ((الخارجي) السياق الموقف): The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text.
- **Homonymy** (المشترك اللفظي): One word with several meanings that are not related.
- **Polysemy** (تعدد المعنى): One word with several meanings that are related.

Every situation has its own words

Always pay attention to context. As the Arabic saying goes, لكلّ مقام مقال: every situation has its own way of speaking.

Micro context and macro context

- **Micro context** (the co-text) is inside the text: the words and sentences around a word.
- **Macro context** is outside the text: the author (for example Nizar Qabbani or Mahmoud Darwish), the audience, the time and place of writing, and the social and historical background.

Picture a triangle with the **author**, the **text** and the **audience** at its three corners. The **translator** stands in the middle and must know all three.

One word, several meanings

Context tells you which meaning is right, whether the meanings are unrelated (**homonymy**) or related (**polysemy**).

- *bank*: مصرف (for money) or ضفّة النهر (of a river). The meanings are unrelated.
- *case*: حالة (a situation), قضية (an issue or a court case) or علبة (a container, such as a phone case). The first two meanings are related; the third is not.
- عين: an eye, a water spring or a spy.
- تطهير: cleaning a wound (تطهير الجرح) or purifying from sins (التطهير من الذنوب). The meanings are related.
- احتجاز: holding water (احتجاز المياه) or holding hostages (احتجاز الرهائن).

Try it

1. Translate *case* in: *The doctor examined the case.*
2. Translate عين in: شربنا من عين ماء باردة.

Answers

1. حالة.
2. *We drank from a cold water spring.*

REMEMBER

- Context decides which meaning is correct.
- Look at the words around a word (micro context) and at the whole situation (macro context).

Part 3: Words that go together

Chapter 7: Collocation

In this chapter. Collocations: the word partners of each language, and how to translate them.

KEY TERMS

- **Collocation** (التلازم اللفظي): Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps.

The company a word keeps

The course materials define collocation as “the company a word keeps”. The idea comes from linguistics: “You shall know a word by the company it keeps” (Firth, 1957, p. 11). Each language has its own partners, so a collocation often cannot be translated word by word (Baker, 2018).

The basic meaning of *pay* is to give money, but its partners change its meaning:

- *pay money* → يدفع المال (the basic meaning)
- *pay attention* → يُدفع الانتباهه or يُعير انتباهه (not الانتباه)
- *pay respect* → يُبدي احتراماً
- *pay a visit* → يقوم بزيارة (not يدفع زيارة)

One English verb may need a different Arabic verb with each partner:

- *deliver a letter* → يسلم رسالة; *deliver a speech* → يلقي خطاباً
- *deliver the news* → ينقل الخبر; *deliver a blow* → يوجه ضربة; *deliver a verdict* → يُصدر حكماً

More collocations

EN → AR

- *close cooperation* → تعاون وثيق; *a close friend* → صديق مقرب
- *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل (not شاي قوي)
- *a fast colour* → لون ثابت; *a fast friend* → صديق وفّي
- *break the law* → يخالف القانون (more natural than يكسر القانون)

AR → EN

- استل سيفه → *he drew his sword*
- يساورني القلق → *I am worried*
- قدّم استقالته → *he resigned*
- اتخذ قراراً → *he made a decision*
- عقد اجتماعاً → *he held a meeting*

Try it

1. Translate: *heavy rain*
2. Translate: *a close friend*
3. Translate: اتخذ قراراً

Answers

1. (مطر ثقيل (not مطر غزير).
2. صديق مقرب.
3. *He made a decision.*

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Translate a collocation with the natural partner in the other language.

Chapter 8: Idioms, proverbs and fixed expressions

In this chapter. How to recognise and translate idioms and proverbs, whose fixed words together mean something new.

KEY TERMS

- **Idiom** (التعبير الاصطلاحي): A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words.
- **Proverb** (المثل): A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth.
- **Fixed expression** (العبارة المسكوكة): A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*.

What is an idiom?

It's a piece of cake means “it is easy”. The words of an idiom are frozen: you cannot change their order or replace one of them.

A **fixed expression** is frozen too, but its meaning is clear from its words: *as a matter of fact* → في واقع الأمر; *ladies and gentlemen* → سيداتي سادتي; *all the best* → مع أطيب التمنيات. Use the expression that the target language uses in the same situation.

How to spot an idiom

- It makes no literal sense: *It's raining cats and dogs*.
- It breaks the rules of grammar: *by and large* (“in general”).
- It is a comparison with *like*: *like two peas in a pod* (“very similar”).
- If an expression makes little sense in its context, it is probably an idiom.

Five ways to translate an idiom

Try them in this order (Baker, 2018):

1. An idiom with the same meaning and the same form, if one exists.

2. An idiom with the same meaning but a different form: *It's raining cats and dogs* → تمطر كأفواه القَرَب.
3. Borrowing the idiom, when readers will understand it.
4. A paraphrase: the meaning in plain words.
5. Omission, only when the idiom adds nothing and cannot be translated.

Check the context first

The same words can sometimes be meant literally. *A piece of cake* usually means “easy” (سهل جداً), but at a birthday party it may simply mean قطعة من الكعكة.

English idioms (EN → AR)

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → تمطر بغزارة
- *to pull one's socks up* → شَمَّر عن ساعديه
- *over the moon* → في قَمَّة السعادة
- *to spill the beans* → أفضى السرَّ
- *I'm all ears.* → كلِّي آذانٍ صاغية
- *Break a leg!* → بالتوفيق!
- *Mark my words.* → تذكّر كلامي
- *to hit the sack* → أوى إلى فراشه
- *Don't put words in my mouth.* → لا تتقول عليّ

Proverbs

Look for a proverb with the same meaning in the other language. If there is none, give the meaning in plain words:

- out of the frying pan into the fire → كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار
- he came back empty-handed → رجع بخُفِّي حُنين

- عصفورٌ في اليد خيرٌ من عشرةٍ على الشجرة → *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush*
- Boys will be boys. → الولد ولد ولو صار قاضي بلد
- Business is business. → تعاشرُوا كالإخوة وتعاملُوا كالأجانب

Try it

1. Translate: *It's a piece of cake.* (about an exam)
2. Translate: *to spill the beans*
3. Translate: رجع بخفّي حنين.

Answers

1. الامتحان سهل جداً.
2. أفشى السرّ.
3. *He came back empty-handed.*

REMEMBER

- Do not translate an idiom word by word unless the other language has the same idiom.
- First check that the expression really is an idiom in this context.
- For proverbs, look for an equivalent proverb; if there is none, give the meaning.

Part 4: Methods and techniques

Chapter 9: Equivalence

In this chapter. The three types of equivalence: formal, functional and ideational (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999).

KEY TERMS

- **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression.
- **Formal equivalence** (التكافؤ الشكلي): Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb.
- **Functional equivalence** (التكافؤ الوظيفي): Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form.
- **Ideational equivalence** (التكافؤ الفكري): Giving only the basic idea, in plain words.

One sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. A “dead letter” is an agreement that exists on paper but is never applied.

- **Formal:** وقد بقيت الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الوقت. The words are correct, but Arab readers will not understand the image.
- **Functional:** بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الوقت. A familiar Arabic idiom: the best choice here.
- **Ideational:** لم تُطبَّق الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الوقت. Clear, but the colour of the idiom is lost.

Note: *agreement* is اتفاقية and *treaty* is معاهدة. Keep the difference.

More examples

- *You should think outside the box.* Formal: عليك أن تفكر خارج الصندوق (now used in Arabic too). Ideational: عليك أن تفكر بطريقة إبداعية.

- *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* Functional: علي لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في كتابة الشعر. Ideational: علي لا يُضاهي في كتابة الشعر.

Try formal equivalence first. If it does not work, look for a functional equivalent. If there is none, give the idea.

The goal is “the closest natural equivalent of the source-language message, first in terms of meaning and secondly in terms of style” (Nida & Taber, 1969, p. 12).

Try it

1. Which type? *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* → علي لا يُضاهي في كتابة الشعر
2. Give a functional equivalent: *The agreement remained a dead letter.*

Answers

1. Ideational: only the basic idea is kept.
2. بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.

REMEMBER

- There are three types of equivalence: formal, functional and ideational.
- Choose the one that gives the closest natural meaning for your reader.

Chapter 10: Literal and free translation

In this chapter. Literal translation, which stays close to the words, and free translation, which stays close to the message.

KEY TERMS

- **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة المعدلة الحرفية).
- **Free translation** (الترجمة الحرة): Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation.
- **Adaptation (method)** (التكييف): A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation.

Literal translation: successful or destructive

Literal translation can be either successful or destructive (قد تكون الترجمة الحرفية ناجحة أو مدمرة). It works only when the target language has the same expression:

- *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً ✓
- *to pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة ✗ (يقوم بزيارة)
- *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً ✗ (لقد كان يوماً طويلاً ✗)
- *What are you wearing on your biggest day?* (in a wedding advert) → ماذا سترتدي في أكبر يوم لديك؟ ✗ (ماذا سترتدي في يوم زفافك؟)

Free translation

Free translation is used for all kinds of texts, not only literary works. But the freer the translation, the greater the risk of adding meaning. Compare these examples from the course materials:

- *Appointing new employees should be done on the basis of equal opportunity.*
→ يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة والمحاباة.
A free translation that keeps the message.

- *Going out can be risky these days.* → a translator who knows the context (for example, the Covid-19 pandemic) might write a sentence about the virus spreading.
- *We have had heavy rainfall this winter.* → ينتظرنا هذا العام موسمٌ زراعيٌّ مبشّر بالخير.
- *His parents are not quite happy about what he said to them.* → a sentence about respecting one's parents.

The last three are very free: they add an interpretation or a new idea. Translation this free comes close to **adaptation**.

Words or meaning?

The principle of translating “not word for word but sense for sense” is very old (Jerome, 395/2012), and the great Abbasid translators followed it too (Baker & Hanna, 2009). As a beginner, translate the meaning, but do not add ideas.

Try it

1. Is this literal translation successful? *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً
2. Correct: *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً طويلاً

Answers

1. Yes: Arabic uses the same expression.
2. لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.

REMEMBER

- Literal translation works only when the target language has the same expression.
- Free translation may change the form, but it should not add new ideas.

Chapter 11: Metaphoric translation

In this chapter. Metaphors and similes, with four steps for translating them.

KEY TERMS

- **Figurative language** (اللغة المجازية): Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect.
- **Metaphor** (الاستعارة): A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning.
- **Simile** (التشبيه): A comparison that uses “as” or “like”.

Metaphor and simile

Metaphor: *He is a lion*. Simile: *He is as brave as a lion*. Poetry is especially rich in metaphors. Note that Arabic rhetoric draws the line differently: هو أسد is a concise simile (تشبيه بليغ), because both sides of the comparison are named. A استعارة names only the image, as in رأيت أسداً يخطب.

Four steps for translating a metaphor

Follow these steps in order. They are based on four of the seven standard procedures for translating metaphors (Newmark, 1988):

1. **If the metaphor is shared** by both languages, translate it literally. *She is a snake.* → إنها أفعى. *My hopes evaporated.* → تبخّرت آمالي. *My paper will see the light of day next December.* → سترى ورقتي البحثية النور في ديسمبر المقبل.
2. **If it is not shared**, replace it with a target-language image with the same meaning. *This is the tip of the iceberg.* → هذا غيضٌ من فيض, or, when something bad is hidden, وما خفي كان أعظم.
3. **Or turn it into a simile:** *He is a rock.* → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته.
4. **If nothing works**, give the basic meaning. This is the last choice, because the image is lost. *The news raised a few eyebrows.* → أثار الخبر استغراب بعضهم.

Try it

1. Translate: *My hopes evaporated.*
2. Translate: *This is only the tip of the iceberg.* (about a scandal)

Answers

1. تبخّرت آمالي.
2. وما خفي كان أعظم. or هذا غيضٌ من فيض.

REMEMBER

- Keep a shared image; replace an unshared one; turn it into a simile; give the plain meaning as a last choice.

Chapter 12: The seven translation procedures

In this chapter. Seven precise techniques, called translation procedures (Vinay & Darbelnet, 1958/1995).

KEY TERMS

- **Translation procedure** (إجراء الترجمة): A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence.
- **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): Taking a word from the source language as it is.
- **Calque** (النسخ): Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 16).
- **Transposition** (الإبدال): Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb.
- **Modulation** (التطويع): Expressing the same idea from another point of view.
- **Equivalence (procedure)** (التكافؤ): Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb.
- **Adaptation (procedure)** (التكييف): Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one.

The seven procedures

The difference between methods and procedures is this: “while translation methods relate to whole texts, translation procedures are used for sentences and the smaller units of language” (Newmark, 1988, p. 81).

The first three are **direct** procedures: they stay close to the original. The last four are **oblique**: they move further away. Use a direct procedure when it gives an accurate, natural result; otherwise, choose an oblique one. Borrowing is used mainly to fill a gap or to keep local colour.

1. **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): *computer* → كمبيوتر
2. **Calque** (النسخ): *skyscraper* → ناطحة سحاب
3. **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): *The book is on the table.* → الكتاب على الطاولة
4. **Transposition** (الإبدال): *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل

5. **Modulation** (التطويع): *It is not difficult.* → إنه سهل
6. **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): *Like father, like son.* → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد
7. **Adaptation** (التكييف): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى

The procedures at work

One sentence often needs several procedures:

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل: transposition
- *press conference* → مؤتمر صحفي: calque
- *Sheraton* → شيراتون: borrowing
- *not impossible* → ممكنة: modulation

Try it

1. Which procedure? *email* → إيميل
2. Which procedure? *honeymoon* → شهر العسل
3. Which procedure? *It is not easy.* → إنه صعب

Answers

1. Borrowing.
2. Calque.
3. Modulation.

REMEMBER

- Procedures 1–3 are direct; 4–7 are oblique.
- Learn their names: you will use them in your commentary (Chapter 25).

Chapter 13: Translation strategies

In this chapter. Strategies: wider plans for solving translation problems (Translation Team, n.d.; Baker, 2018).

KEY TERMS

- **Translation strategy** (استراتيجية الترجمة): A planned solution to a translation problem.
- **Functional translation** (الترجمة الوظيفية): Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function.
- **Cultural substitution** (الاستبدال الثقافي): Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader.
- **Addition** (الإضافة): Adding words or information that the reader needs.
- **Omission** (الحذف): Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language.
- **Explanatory translation** (الترجمة الشرحية): Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent.
- **Compensation** (التعويض): Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere.
- **Domestication** (التوطين): Making a translation feel local to the target reader.
- **Foreignisation** (التفريب): Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text.

Strategies from the course materials

1. **Literal and idiomatic translation:** translating literally when the result is natural, and translating an idiom with another idiom when possible. Check the field even for simple terms: *key word* can be كلمة مفتاحية or كلمة دالة, depending on the field.
2. **Functional translation:** *a dead letter* → حبرٌ على ورق; *second to none* → لا يُشَقَّ له غبار (Chapter 9). When there is no matching expression, give the plain meaning: *spill the beans* → يُفشي السرّ; *mark my words* → تذكّر كلامي.
3. **Cultural substitution** (adaptation, Chapter 12): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى.
4. **Addition:** common from English into Arabic, because Arabic style often favours fuller expression (الإطناب), and Arab readers may need information

that English readers already have. *the Fed* → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي.

5. **Omission:** common from Arabic into English, where repeated synonyms sound unnatural. شجاعٌ مِغوار → *very brave*. It is also used to avoid words that would offend the reader. Never omit real information.
6. **Explanatory translation:** the last option, used for cultural and religious terms such as الزكاة and العِدَّة, and for dense technical terms (Chapter 15).

Other useful strategies

Translators also use these strategies (Baker, 2018):

1. **A more general word:** when the target language has no exact word. *prawns* and *shrimps* → روبيان.
2. **A more neutral word:** when the source word carries a feeling that would sound wrong in the target text.
3. **Paraphrase:** explaining the meaning in other words. *jet lag* → الإرهاق الناتج عن فارق التوقيت.
4. **Loan word plus explanation:** explain the word the first time, then use it alone: *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam). Many Arabic words entered English this way: *algebra*, *algorithm*, *hijab*.
5. **Substitution:** using what the target reader expects, especially for times and measures: 3 → الثالثة فجراً; 7:40 → الثامنة إلا ثلاثاً a.m.
6. **Compensation:** if a pun or a rhyme is lost in one sentence, create a similar effect elsewhere (Dickins et al., 2016).

Domestication and foreignisation

For the text as a whole, **domestication** makes it feel local to the reader, and **foreignisation** keeps its foreign flavour (Venuti, 1995). For example, in an English text, الديوانية can become *a men's evening gathering* (domestication) or stay *the diwaniya* (foreignisation). Let the brief decide (Chapter 2).

Try it

1. Which strategy? شجاعٌ مغوار → *very brave*
2. Which strategy? *Romeo and Juliet* → قيس وليلى
3. Why is addition common from English into Arabic?

Answers

1. Omission.
2. Cultural substitution.
3. Because Arabic style often favours fuller expression, and Arab readers may need extra information.

REMEMBER

- Choose the right strategy for each problem; do not use the same one everywhere.
- Explanatory translation is the last option.
- Decide, with the brief, whether the text should feel local or foreign.

Part 5: Culture and new words

Chapter 14: Cultural approximation

In this chapter. How to bring cultural meaning close to your reader. This is the hardest kind of approximation.

KEY TERMS

- **Cultural approximation** (التقريب الثقافي): Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader.
- **Culture-specific item** (عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture.

What is cultural approximation?

Cultural approximation needs a good knowledge of both cultures. When an image carries a different feeling in the other culture, translate the feeling, not the picture.

Expressions with a cultural equivalent

- *I have got the test in the bag.* → الامتحان في جيبِي (informal: it is guaranteed)
- *Like mother, like daughter.* → اقلب الجرّة على فمها تطلع البنت لأُمّها (a colloquial proverb)
- *Ali and Ahmad are cut from the same cloth.* → عليّ وأحمد من طينة واحدة
- *a scapegoat* → كبش فداء
- *to sleep like a log* → نام كالقتيل
- *as busy as a bee* → نشيط كالنحلة

When climate changes meaning

The news warmed my heart becomes أثلجَ الخبرُ صدري: in a hot climate, relief feels cold. So a translator of Shakespeare's line "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" (Shakespeare, 1609) may choose spring for Arab readers: أَشَبّهَكَ بيومٍ ربيعِي؟

Titles and institutions

Translate the job, not the words:

- *the Home Office* (UK) → وزارة الداخلية البريطانية
- *the Chancellor of the Exchequer* (UK) → وزير المالية البريطاني
- *the Secretary of the Treasury* (US) → وزير الخزانة الأمريكي
- *the Secretary of State* (US) → وزير الخارجية الأمريكي
- *sheriff* (US) → رئيس شرطة المقاطعة

Culture in the media and business

- *watchdog press* → الصحافة الرقابية; *lapdog press* → الصحافة الموالية
- *mocktail* (a drink without alcohol) → مشروب مُنعش بلا كحول
- *product cannibalisation* (a new product takes sales from another product of the same company) → مزاحمة منتج جديد لمنتج آخر للشركة نفسها

Social expressions

Use the phrase people actually say in the same situation, in the variety of Arabic that suits your reader:

- *God willing.* → إن شاء الله
- *We are very well.* → الحمد لله، بخير
- *Welcome! It is an honour to have you here.* → أهلاً وسهلاً، شَرَفْتُمُونَا
- *I am sorry for your loss.* → عَظُمَ اللهُ أَجْرَكُمْ (formal); in Egyptian Arabic, البقية في حياتك
- *Thank you for your hard work.* → يعطيك العافية (Gulf and Levantine spoken Arabic)

Try it

1. Translate: *cut from the same cloth*
2. Translate: *the Secretary of State* (US)
3. Why does *warm* my heart become *أثلج صدري*?

Answers

1. من طينة واحدة.
2. وزير الخارجية الأمريكي.
3. In a hot climate, relief is linked with coolness, not warmth.

REMEMBER

- Translate the effect, not the image.
- Use what a target-language speaker would say in the same situation.

Chapter 15: Descriptive translation

In this chapter. How to explain a word when the target language has no word and no similar custom.

KEY TERMS

- **Descriptive translation** (الترجمة الوصفية): Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية), Chapter 13).
- **Transliteration** (النقل الصوتي): Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language.
- **Concept** (المفهوم): An idea that a word or term stands for.

How to do it

1. **Transliterate** the source word, for example *zakat*.
2. **Describe** its meaning, in brackets after the word or in a footnote.
3. Describe it **only the first time**. After that, the transliterated word is enough.

When readers do not need the source word, give the description alone, as in the last example below. Use descriptive translation as the last option, because it makes the text longer. It suits cultural words and complex technical terms.

Examples

- الزكاة → *zakat* (obligatory annual alms in Islam: a fixed share of savings and wealth above a minimum amount, given to those in need)
- التيمم → *tayammum* (dry ritual purification: wiping the face and hands with clean earth when water is missing or cannot be used)
- البسملة → *the basmala* (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
- الحوقلة → *the hawqala* (saying “There is no might and no power except by God”)

- العِدَّة → 'idda (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)
- العِطْوَة → 'atwa (a temporary truce in tribal customary law, for example in Jordan)
- Ali has been sectioned. (UK) → أُدخل عليّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية بموجب القانون

Try it

1. Translate for English readers: الوقف
2. Where can you put the description?

Answers

1. *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam).
2. In brackets after the word, or in a footnote.

REMEMBER

- Transliterate first, then describe.
- Describe only the first time a word appears.
- Use it as the last option.

Chapter 16: Lexical creation

In this chapter. Why and how translators coin new words.

KEY TERMS

- **Lexical creation** (التوليد المعجمي): Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent.
- **Neologism** (اللفظ المستحدث): A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning.
- **Loan translation (calque)** (النسخ): Translating the parts of a compound word one by one.

Why new words are needed

Some cultural, religious, political or technical concepts have no equivalent, because the target language has a gap in its vocabulary. The translator then has to coin a word.

Five ways to create a word

1. **Neologism:** a new word, often derived from an Arabic root (الاشتقاق), or an old word with a new meaning. *blog* → مدوّنة (from دَوَّن, “to write down”)
2. **Loan translation (calque):** *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي; *shadow government* → حكومة الظل; *Thanksgiving* → عيد الشكر
3. **Transliteration** (borrowing), with a short definition the first time: الوقف → *waqf* (a charitable endowment); الصكوك → *sukuk* (Islamic investment certificates). Into Arabic, this is called arabicisation (التعريب): *radio* → الراديو
4. **Explanation:** *greenwashing* → التضليل البيئي (when companies falsely claim that their products are environmentally friendly)
5. **Hybrid form:** part translated, part borrowed. *cybersecurity* → الأمن السيبراني

Arabic also coins words by blending two words into one, called النحت: *amphibious* → برمائي (برّ + ماء).

Search before you create

First search for an accepted term. The Arabic language academies, UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.) record many new terms. For example: *global warming* → الاحترار العالمي; *greenhouse effect* → الاحتباس الحراري; *cancel culture* → ثقافة الإلغاء.

An accepted term is always better than a new invention. A new word that becomes widely accepted and enters the dictionary is lexicalised (المُعْجَمَة).

Try it

1. Which method? *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي
2. What should you do before creating a new word?

Answers

1. Loan translation (calque).
2. Search for an accepted term in the academies, UNTERM or Arabterm.

REMEMBER

- Create a new word only when no accepted term exists.
- The five methods: neologism, calque, transliteration, explanation and hybrid form.

Part 6: Working with whole texts

Chapter 17: Text analysis

In this chapter. How to analyse a text: the first of three phases, followed by translation and commentary.

KEY TERMS

- **Text** (النص): Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book.
- **Text analysis** (تحليل النص): Breaking down and studying a text before translating it.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem.
- **Tone** (النبذة): The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, friendly, straightforward.
- **Field** (المجال): The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law.

Why analyse before translating?

- Each new reading brings new ideas.
- You identify the field, the source and target audiences, the time, purpose, tone and genre.
- You find difficult terms early, so you translate faster.
- You choose your strategies and see what resources you need.
- You form a mental draft of the translation (Nord, 2005).

Begin “by reading the original for two purposes: first, to understand what it is about; second, to analyse it from a ‘translator’s’ point of view” (Newmark, 1988, Chapter 2).

Analysis is not a summary

A **summary** gives only the facts. An **analysis** looks at who wrote the text, for whom, why and how. When asked to analyse, do not summarise.

The analysis checklist

Answer these questions for every text:

1. Who is the author or speaker?
2. Who published it?
3. What is the field?
4. What is the genre and the purpose?
5. What is the tone, and what is the style of writing?
6. Who is the target audience?
7. Which terms and words need checking?
8. Which strategies will you use?

An example

A short KUNA news report about relations with Australia. **Field:** politics. **Genre and purpose:** news report, to inform. **Tone:** neutral and straightforward. **Publisher:** KUNA. **Audience:** readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East. **Style:** formal, with no short forms. **Strategy:** mostly literal, because the text has no metaphors.

A good analyst

- keeps training his or her analytical skills;
- builds his or her own model of analysis;
- makes the translation match the analysis: a formal tone means a formal translation;
- notes the text's problems, so the commentary can explain the solutions.

Try it

1. What is the difference between an analysis and a summary?
2. Name the three phases of translation.

Answers

1. A summary gives the facts; an analysis describes the features, background, purpose and style.
2. Analysis, translation and commentary.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis.

Chapter 18: Text types and genres

In this chapter. Why genre matters, with an example of each main genre.

KEY TERMS

- **Text type** (نمط النص): A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report or a recipe.
- **Headline** (العنوان الرئيسي): The title of a news story.
- **Inverted pyramid** (الهرم المقلوب): A news structure that gives the most important facts first.

Three main functions

Texts can be grouped by their main function (Reiss, 2000). **Informative** texts give facts, **expressive** texts are creative and focus on form, as in literature, and **operative** texts persuade.

Main genres, with examples

- **News:** facts, neutral tone and short headlines. *Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.* → ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
- **Legal:** exact words; *shall* expresses an obligation or a legal rule. *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* → تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
- **Political:** careful, sensitive words. *The two sides held frank and constructive talks.* → أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.
- **Medical:** no ambiguity and exact doses. *Take one tablet twice daily.* → تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
- **Technical:** clear instructions and consistent terms. *Press and hold the power button.* → اضغط مطوئاً على زر التشغيل.
- **Literary:** feeling, voice and natural dialogue. *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.

- **Poetry:** images and rhythm, with more freedom. الخيلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني (al-Mutanabbi, n.d.) → *The horses, the night and the desert know me.*
- **Advertising:** persuasion and rhythm. *Save more. Smile more.* → وفّر أكثر...! وابتسم أكثر!

Translating news headlines

English headlines have their own grammar:

- No *a, the* or *is*. A passive headline often becomes a verbal noun (مصدر) in Arabic: *Man killed, woman wounded in shooting* → مقتل رجل وإصابة امرأة في إطلاق نار.
- The simple present reports a recent event: *Minister opens new hospital* → الوزير يفتتح مستشفى جديداً.
- *to + verb* means the future: *Saudi Arabia to extend visas for expats* → السعودية ستمدّد تأشيرات الوافدين.
- Add what Arab readers may not know: *Mustang customer complaint* → شكوى زبون من سيارة فورد موستانج.

How a news story is built

Most news stories follow the **inverted pyramid**: the most important facts come first, in the headline and the first paragraph (the lead), and the details follow. Keep this order in your translation.

Hard news reports facts, such as decisions, disasters and discoveries, without the writer's opinion. **Soft news** tells human stories, to interest or move the reader.

Technical and literary texts

In technical texts, one word can be a different term in each field: *depression* is الاكتئاب in psychology, الكساد in economics and منخفض جوي in a weather report. Check the field every time (Chapter 21).

In literary texts, **style** matters as much as content: word choice, sentence length, tone and dialogue. If a character speaks in dialect to show who they are, find a way to keep that effect.

Try it

1. Which text type is an advert: informative, expressive or operative?
2. Why does a medical text need exact words?

Answers

1. Operative: it tries to persuade.
2. Because a mistake, such as a wrong dose, can harm the reader.

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre before you translate.
- Follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.
- News headlines have their own grammar; translate them into natural Arabic headlines.

Chapter 19: Words and points of view

In this chapter. How to notice words that show a point of view, using three simple questions.

KEY TERMS

- **Ideology** (الأيدولوجيا): A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events.
- **Loaded word** (كلمة مشحونة): A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative.

Words are rarely neutral

Many word choices show a point of view, and your translation can keep, soften or strengthen it. Follow the client's policy on sensitive words (Chapter 2).

- *A suicide bomber killed ten people.* → انتحاري or استشهادي, depending on the client's policy: the same person seen from opposite points of view.
- *regime or government* (حكومة or نظام): in political texts, "regime" is negative.
- *Protesters were killed.* (قُتل متظاهرون): the passive hides who did the killing.

Three questions to ask

Language is connected to power and society (Fairclough, 1992). This gives us three questions:

1. **The words:** which words show a judgement? Who is shown doing what, and who is hidden?
2. **The writer:** who wrote the text, for which newspaper or organisation, and for which readers?
3. **The purpose:** whose interests does the text serve?

Try it

1. Why is *regime* not neutral?
2. What does the passive in *Protesters were killed* hide?

Answers

1. It suggests a harsh or illegitimate government.
2. Who did the killing.

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words and hidden doers.
- Follow the client's policy, and explain sensitive choices in your commentary.

Part 7: Tools and resources

Chapter 20: Printed and digital dictionaries

In this chapter. Which dictionaries to use, and how to use them well.

KEY TERMS

- **Bilingual dictionary** (معجم ثنائي اللغة): A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language.
- **Monolingual dictionary** (معجم أحادي اللغة): A dictionary that explains words in the same language.
- **Specialised dictionary** (معجم متخصص): A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine.
- **Collocations dictionary** (معجم المتلازمات): A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language.

A dictionary gives options, not answers

A famous saying goes: “Dictionaries are like watches; the worst is better than none, and the best cannot be expected to go quite true” (Johnson, 1784/1897). Do not simply take the first meaning. Use the three-check rule:

1. Find the options in a **bilingual dictionary**.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual dictionary**.
3. See how the word is really used in a text written in the target language.

For a *fast colour*, a bilingual dictionary gives سريع and ثابت. An Arabic dictionary confirms that ثابت can mean “not fading”, and clothing labels use لون ثابت. So the answer is لون ثابت.

Printed and digital dictionaries

- **Printed dictionaries:** edited by experts, with full entries and examples, but slower to use, and they may lack new words.

- **Digital dictionaries:** fast and often updated, but quality varies. Check the publisher: a digital version of a known printed dictionary is safer than an unknown website.

Useful dictionaries

- *Al-Mawrid* (Baalbaki, n.d.): English–Arabic, for general words.
- *A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic* (Wehr, 1994): Arabic–English, with words listed by root.
- *Al-Muʿjam al-Wasīṭ* (المعجم الوسيط) (Academy of the Arabic Language, n.d.): a monolingual Arabic dictionary from the Academy in Cairo.
- *Oxford Collocations Dictionary for Students of English* (2009): natural English word partners.
- UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.): official and technical terms.

Try it

1. Which dictionary do you use to confirm a meaning?
2. What should you check before trusting a digital dictionary?

Answers

1. A monolingual dictionary.
2. Who publishes it.

REMEMBER

- Check a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.
- Use printed and digital dictionaries together; check digital sources.

Chapter 21: Terminology and terminology management

In this chapter. What terms are, and how to find, record and use them consistently.

KEY TERMS

- **Term** (المصطلح): A word or expression that names a concept in a special field.
- **Terminology** (علم المصطلح (المصطلحية)): The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field.
- **Terminologist** (المصطلحي (خبير المصطلحات)): A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes standardises them, in one or more languages.
- **Term list** (قائمة المصطلحات): A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations.
- **Termbase** (قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات (بنك المصطلحات)): A database of terms and information about them.
- **Terminology guide** (دليل المصطلحات): A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client.

What is terminology?

Every field, such as law or medicine, has its own **terms**. One wrong term can change the meaning of a contract or a medical instruction.

Terminology is the study of how terms are collected, named and managed (Cabr , 1999).

The translator and the terminologist

- A **translator** works across two languages and uses terms from glossaries, dictionaries and termbases.
- A **terminologist** studies the terms of a field rather than whole texts: they collect, record and sometimes standardise them, in one or more languages.
- When no dictionary or termbase has the term, think like a terminologist and create an accurate one (Chapter 16).

Why manage terms?

Unmanaged terms give one concept several names. Readers get confused, and earlier translations cannot be reused. Do not change an accepted term without a good reason.

Short forms

- **Initialism:** letters read one by one: *CIA*, *CBC* (complete blood count).
- **Acronym:** letters read as a word: *LASER*.
- **Abbreviation:** part of a word: *vol.* (volume).
- **Clipping:** a word cut short, often keeping its first part: *super* (superintendent).

What makes a good term?

It is clear, short, has one meaning and follows the language's normal rules for making words.

The Arabic language academies

The Arabic language academies (مجامع اللغة العربية), for example in Damascus, Cairo, Baghdad and Amman, create and approve Arabic terms (Translation Team, n.d.). The Coordination Bureau of Arabization in Rabat (مكتب تنسيق التعريب) helps to unify them across the Arab world.

How to translate a term

1. **Understand** its exact meaning in its field.
2. **Look at its origin:** its parts often explain it.
3. **Find the equivalent** in the academies, UNTERM, Arabterm or the client's guide. If none exists, create one (Chapter 16).
4. **Record** it in your term list, and **share** the list with your team.

A simple term list

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Also القانون المطبَّق; القانون الحاكم is a common calque
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	A contract condition
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادّة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> is بند
CBC	تعداد الدم الكامل	Medical	Also صورة الدم الكاملة

Tools for terms

- **Specialised dictionary** (Chapter 20): the terms of one field.
- **Termbase**: each entry holds the term in each language, with its definition, field, source and date. A team can share and update it.
- **Terminology guide**: the client's approved terms and writing rules. Always ask for one, and follow it.

The golden rule: one term for one idea

Use the same term throughout. If *Article* is مادّة in the first paragraph, do not switch to بند later “for variety”. A new word suggests a new meaning.

Try it

1. What is the difference between a translator and a terminologist?
2. Is *LASER* an initialism or an acronym?
3. What should you do when no dictionary gives you the term?

Answers

1. A translator translates whole texts; a terminologist collects, records and sometimes standardises the terms of a field.
2. An acronym: the letters are read as a word.
3. Think like a terminologist: create an accurate equivalent and record it.

REMEMBER

- Keep a term list for every project, and ask for the client's guide.
- Search the academies, UNTERM and Arabterm before you create a term.
- Use one term for one idea.

Chapter 22: Machine translation and AI

In this chapter. How to use machine translation and AI tools safely.

KEY TERMS

- **Machine translation (MT)** (الترجمة الآلية): Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools.
- **Post-editing** (التحرير اللاحق): A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully.
- **Hallucination** (الهلوسة): Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text.
- **Translation memory** (ذاكرة الترجمة): A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse.
- **CAT tool** (أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب): Software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase.
- **Localisation** (الأقلمة): Adapting a whole product, such as a website, an app or a game, to a local market.

Tools translators use

- **Machine translation:** early systems used rules, then statistics; today most use neural networks. They are much more fluent, but they can still be wrong.
- **Translation memory:** stores your past translations sentence by sentence and suggests them when a similar sentence appears. It saves time and keeps your work consistent.
- **Termbases:** keep one term for one idea across a project (Chapter 21).
- **CAT tools** combine these, for example Trados, memoQ, and the free OmegaT and Matecat.

Useful or risky?

Machine translation can give a first draft of a simple text, or help you check your ideas. It is risky for legal, medical and religious texts, idioms, poetry and confidential texts.

You, not the machine, are responsible for the final translation (Kenny, 2022).

Typical mistakes

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً: the idiom is translated word by word. Correct: تمطر بغزارة.
- *The doctor finished her shift.* → أنهى الطبيب نوبته: the machine guessed a man. Correct: أنهت الطبيبة نوبتها.
- AI tools may add facts that are not in the text (hallucination).

Post-editing: the new direction

The course materials call post-editing the new direction for translators worldwide (Translation Team, n.d.). **Light** post-editing (التحرير اللاحق الخفيف) makes the text accurate and understandable; **full** post-editing (التحرير اللاحق الكامل) also makes it natural and ready to publish. Compare the machine output with the source sentence by sentence, then read it again as a normal text.

Post-editing: an example

Our new branch opens on Monday. Don't miss out!

- Machine output: !فرعنا الجديد يفتح يوم الاثنين. لا تفوّت الخروج (miss out was read as "going out")
- Post-edited: !يُفتتح فرعنا الجديد يوم الاثنين. لا تفوّتوا الفرصة ✓

Using AI tools well

- Tell the tool the text type, the audience and the terms you want.
- Ask for two or three options, then choose yourself.
- Check every name, number, date and term against a reliable source.

Localisation

Localisation adapts a whole product to a local market. Translation is one part of it. The rest includes dates, numbers, currencies and units, images and colours, and the direction of the page: an Arabic website reads from right to left.

Four rules

1. You are responsible for every word.
2. Never put a client's private text into a public AI tool.
3. Check terms, names, numbers, idioms and every "not".
4. Tell the client if you used a machine or AI.

Try it

1. Should you paste a client's confidential contract into a free AI tool?
2. What is post-editing?

Answers

1. No, never.
2. A human correcting and improving machine translation.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.
- Always post-edit, and protect your client's privacy.

Part 8: Checking and explaining

Chapter 23: Revision and common mistakes

In this chapter. How to revise your translation, with a reference list of common mistakes.

KEY TERMS

- **Draft** (المسودة): The first version of a translation.
- **Revision** (المراجعة): Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.

Three readings

Every translator makes mistakes in a draft, even experts; revision is where you find them. Checking your own draft is called **self-revision** (Mossop, 2014).

1. **With the original:** is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Without the original:** does it sound natural? If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.
3. **The details:** numbers, names, spelling, punctuation, titles and captions.

Common mistakes in Arabic (EN → AR)

- Starting every sentence with the subject (correct, but it sounds translated):
...الحكومة أعلنت... → أعلنت الحكومة
- Overusing: قام بـ: قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت → زار الوزير الكويت
- Copying the English passive: تم افتتاح المعرض من قبل الوزير → افتتح الوزير المعرض
- Numbers 3 to 10: ثلاث طلاب → ثلاثة طلاب
- Hamza and taa marbuta: إنشاء، مدرسه، الى → إنشاء، مدرسة، إلى
- Word-for-word collocations: كسر القانون → خالف القانون
- English punctuation: نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ → نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ أنت؟

Common mistakes in English (AR → EN)

- Long sentences joined with “and”: split them with full stops.
- Repeated synonyms: *brave and daring* → *very brave*
- An extra “the”: *The life is beautiful.* → *Life is beautiful.*
- A missing “is”: *He in the office.* → *He is in the office.*
- Arabic prepositions: *He married from her.* → *He married her.*
- Missing capital letters in a title before a name: *minister of health Ahmad Ali* → *Minister of Health Ahmad Ali*

Try it

1. Improve: *قام المدير بتوقيع العقد.*
2. Improve: *She is a doctor in the hospital and she works hard and she likes her job.*

Answers

1. *وقع المديرُ العقد.*
2. *She is a doctor at the hospital. She works hard and likes her job.*

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the original.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

Chapter 24: Interlingual risk assessment

In this chapter. A simple risk matrix that shows where to check most carefully in English–Arabic translation.

KEY TERMS

- **Risk** (الخطر): The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be.
- **Risk management** (إدارة المخاطر): Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm.
- **Risk matrix** (مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر): A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do.

Why assess risk?

A wrong dose in a medicine leaflet or a missing “not” in a contract can cause real harm. Translating can be seen as risk management: the more serious the possible harm, the more care a text needs (Pym, 2015).

The interlingual risk matrix

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Terms	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الواجب التطبيق	High in legal texts	Check a specialised dictionary and the term list
Negatives	A lost “not” reverses the meaning	High	Compare sentence by sentence
Numbers and dates	A wrong dose; Hijri or Gregorian date	High	Check every figure twice
Legal verbs	<i>shall</i> → سوف ✗	High in contracts	Use the Arabic present tense for obligations
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf</i> / <i>Arabian Gulf</i>	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy; explain in the commentary
Ideological words	انتحاري / استشهادي	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy (Chapter 19)
Cultural images	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي ✗	Medium	Use cultural approximation (Chapter 14)

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Words with several meanings	علم: flag, knowledge or “taught”?	Medium	Read the context (Chapter 6)
Style and register	A dialect word in a formal report	Low to medium	Re-read with the brief in mind
Idioms	An idiom translated word by word	Low to medium	Check whether it is an idiom (Chapter 8)

How to use the matrix

1. Before you deliver, check your translation against each row.
2. Give most time to the high-risk areas.
3. For high-risk texts, such as legal and medical ones, ask a second person to check.

Example: *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* →
 تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت. (not سوف تخضع).

Try it

1. What is the main risk in *Take one tablet twice daily*?
2. What should you do with a high-risk text?

Answers

1. The dose: the numbers must be exactly right.
2. Check it with extra care, and ask a second person to review it.

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives, terms and legal verbs every time.
- The higher the risk, the more careful the check.

Chapter 25: Translation commentary

In this chapter. How to write a commentary, the third phase, which explains and justifies your choices.

KEY TERMS

- **Translation commentary** (التعليق على الترجمة): A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.
- **Justification** (التبرير): The reason why a translation choice is right.

What a commentary is for

A commentary shows your thinking, like showing your working in a maths exam. It sharpens your reasoning and helps you judge translations, your own and other people's (Dickins et al., 2016).

Two parts

1. **Reflecting on your analysis:** which problems did it identify?
2. **Reflecting on your translation:** how did you solve each problem?

Five steps for each problem

1. **The problem:** what was difficult?
2. **The solution:** what did you write?
3. **The procedure or strategy:** which technique did you use (Chapters 9 to 16)?
4. **The resource:** which dictionary or source did you check?
5. **The justification:** why is your choice right for the reader?

Rules

- Write in the **third person**: "The translator faced...", "The translator changed some parts to make them more comprehensible..."

- Let WH-questions guide you: what, why, how?
- Always give examples from the source and the translation.
- Explain omissions, for example: “This was omitted because it is irrelevant to the target audience.”
- Mention the dictionaries and resources you used.
- Keep it short and clear.

An example

The source text says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose the functional equivalent حبراً على ورق. The expression was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of a news report.

Try it

1. Write one commentary sentence for *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل.

Answers

1. For example: “*Strong tea* is a collocation, so it could not be translated word by word; the translator used the Arabic partner شاي ثقيل, which sounds natural to Arab readers.”

REMEMBER

- Analysis → translation → commentary.
- For each problem: problem, solution, procedure or strategy, resource, justification.

Part 9: Audiovisual translation

Chapter 26: Introduction to audiovisual translation

In this chapter. What audiovisual translation is, its main types, one useful idea and its challenges.

KEY TERMS

- **Audiovisual translation (AVT)** (الترجمة السمعية البصرية): Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games.
- **Dubbing** (الدبلجة): Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language.
- **Voice-over** (التعليق الصوتي): Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly.
- **Audio description** (الوصف الصوتي): A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers.
- **Skopos theory** (نظرية الغاية): The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated.

Why AVT matters

Films, series, games and online videos are part of almost everyone's life today (Pérez-González, 2014). Driven by technology, AVT is one of the fastest-growing areas of Translation Studies.

What makes AVT different?

- It depends heavily on technology.
- **Images, sound** (dialogue, music, sound effects) and **written words** on screen work together to make meaning.
- The translator must connect the words with the pictures and sound (Gambier, 2003).

Types of AVT

- **Subtitling:** written text on the screen (Chapter 27).
- **Dubbing:** new dialogue in the target language, often matched to the actors' lips.
- **Voice-over:** a translation read over the original voice, as in documentaries.
- **Audio description:** a spoken description of the action, for blind and partially sighted viewers.

Dubbing

Dubbing is used for cartoons, games and commercials, and in the Arab world for many children's programmes and series. Its challenges are matching lip movements, adapting cultural content and staying consistent across a series. When the cartoon *The Simpsons* was dubbed into Arabic as آل شمشون, the family's habits were adapted for Arab family viewers: Homer's beer, for example, became a soft drink.

One useful idea: purpose first

Before you translate a video, ask what it is for and who will watch it. This is **Skopos theory** (Reiss & Vermeer, 1984). A cartoon for children and a documentary for adults need very different choices.

Why AVT is challenging

- **Culture:** a reference may have no equivalent (Chapters 14 to 16).
- **Language:** English and Arabic are built differently, yet you must be accurate and brief (Chapter 3).
- **Technology:** subtitles have strict limits of space and time.
- **Creativity:** jokes, wordplay, songs and slang need creative solutions.

How to start

1. Watch the whole video first, then read the script or dialogue list.
2. Ask for the brief: subtitles or dubbing? For which viewers? In which Arabic?
3. Practise with free subtitling software, such as Subtitle Edit or Aegisub.
4. Watch films with Arabic subtitles and notice what the subtitler shortened.

Try it

1. What are the three elements of an audiovisual text?
2. Which type of AVT describes the action on screen for blind viewers?
3. What does Skopos theory put first?

Answers

1. Images, sound and written words.
2. Audio description.
3. The purpose of the translation.

REMEMBER

- AVT combines images, sound and words, and depends on technology.
- Main types: subtitling, dubbing, voice-over and audio description.
- The purpose and the viewers decide how you translate.

Chapter 27: Subtitling

In this chapter. What subtitles are, their main kinds, and how to handle cultural references and strong language.

KEY TERMS

- **Subtitling** (الترجمة المرئية / السترجة): Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics.
- **Dialogue list** (قائمة الحوار): A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator.
- **Culture-bound term** (مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 14).
- **Taboo language** (اللغة المحظورة): Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words.
- **Censorship** (الرقابة): Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable.

What is a subtitle?

A subtitle normally has one or two lines. Each line traditionally holds about 37 to 39 characters; streaming platforms now allow up to 42. It must stay on screen long enough to be read, usually from about one to six or seven seconds, and appear and disappear with the speech (**spotting**) (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2021). Always follow the client's guidelines.

Kinds of subtitles

- **Intralingual**: the same language as the dialogue, for example subtitles for the deaf and hard of hearing (**SDH**), which also describe important sounds, or subtitles for language learners.
- **Interlingual**: another language; what translators usually make.
- **Pre-prepared** (offline) or **live** (online), as in live news.
- **Open** (burned into the picture) or **closed** (can be turned on and off).

Subtitling step by step

1. Watch the whole film or video, with the dialogue list if you have one.
2. **Spot** the subtitles: mark when each one starts and ends.
3. Translate the meaning of each line.
4. **Condense**: cut what viewers can see or do not need, such as repetitions and fillers like *well* and *you know*.
5. Check the length, reading time and line breaks, then watch the video with your subtitles.

An example

Well, you know, I really don't think we should go out tonight, because it's going to rain.

لا أظن أن علينا الخروج الليلة، فالمطر قادم.

The fillers disappear, and the meaning stays.

Arabic subtitles

- Write in Modern Standard Arabic, even when the characters speak a dialect, unless the client asks otherwise.
- Break a line where the meaning breaks: keep a noun with its adjective, and a preposition with its noun.
- Use Arabic punctuation.

Words, images and sound

A good subtitle works with the images, dialogue, music and sound effects:

- If the picture already shows something, the subtitle can be shorter.
- If the picture is unclear, the subtitle can explain it.

Why subtitling is hard

- Viewers who know some of the source language hear the original and read your translation, so they notice mistakes.
- Speech becomes writing and must be cut down to short lines.
- How characters speak shows who they are: their **sociolect** (social group), **slang** and **idiolect** (personal habits). Try to keep this.

Cultural references

Cultural references may be **geographical** (places), **ethnographic** (food, holidays, daily life) or **socio-political** (government, institutions) (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007).

The most useful strategies are (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007; Pedersen, 2011):

1. **Loan** (retention): keep the source word.
2. **Calque** (direct translation): translate it word for word.
3. **Explicitation** (specification): add a little information.
4. **Generalisation**: use a more general word.
5. **Substitution**: use something familiar to the audience.
6. **Official equivalent**: use the accepted translation, if there is one.
7. **Compensation**: make up for a lost effect somewhere else.
8. **Omission**: leave it out when it is unimportant and there is no space.

You met most of these in Chapters 12 and 13. In subtitling, you must also respect limits of space and time.

Strong and taboo language

Films use **taboo language**, such as swearing, for realism, character or humour. Subtitlers often soften it, for several reasons: swear words look stronger in writing than in speech; audiences have different norms; and broadcasters or authorities may require it (**censorship**), or subtitlers may choose it themselves (self-

censorship). Follow the client's guidelines, and keep the emotion of the scene where you can.

Try it

1. What is the difference between open and closed subtitles?
2. Which strategy uses an accepted translation?
3. Why do viewers notice mistakes in subtitles easily?

Answers

1. Open subtitles are burned into the picture; closed subtitles can be turned on and off.
2. The official equivalent.
3. Because they hear the original and read the translation at the same time, and many understand some of the original.

REMEMBER

- A subtitle normally has no more than two short lines, stays on screen long enough to be read, and works with images and sound.
- Choose a strategy for each cultural reference, within the limits of space and time.
- Follow the client's guidelines on strong language.

Glossary

All the key terms defined in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the chapter where each one is explained.

Adaptation (method) التكيف A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation. (Chapter 10)

Adaptation (procedure) التكيف Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one. (Chapter 12)

Addition الإضافة Adding words or information that the reader needs. (Chapter 13)

Approximation التقريب Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible. (Chapter 1)

Audio description الوصف الصوتي A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers. (Chapter 26)

Audiovisual translation (AVT) الترجمة السمعية البصرية Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games. (Chapter 26)

Bilingual dictionary معجم ثنائي اللغة A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language. (Chapter 20)

Borrowing الاقتراض Taking a word from the source language as it is. (Chapter 12)

Calque النسخ Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 16). (Chapter 12)

CAT tool أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب Software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase. (Chapter 22)

Censorship الرقابة Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable. (Chapter 27)

Client العميل The person or organisation that asks for a translation. (Chapter 2)

Collocation التلازم اللفظي Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps. (Chapter 7)

Collocations dictionary معجم المتلازمات A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language. (Chapter 20)

Commissioned translator مترجم بتكليف A translator who translates a text at someone else's request. (Chapter 1)

Communicative purpose الغرض التواصل What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain. (Chapter 2)

Compensation التعويض Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere. (Chapter 13)

Concept المفهوم An idea that a word or term stands for. (Chapter 15)

Connotation المعنى الإيحائي The extra feeling or association a word carries. (Chapter 5)

Context السياق Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation. (Chapter 6)

Cultural approximation التقريب الثقافي Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader. (Chapter 14)

Cultural substitution الاستبدال الثقافي Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Culture-bound term مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 14). (Chapter 27)

Culture-specific item عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture. (Chapter 14)

Denotation المعنى المعجمي The basic, dictionary meaning of a word. (Chapter 5)

Descriptive translation الترجمة الوصفية Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية), Chapter 13). (Chapter 15)

Dialect اللهجة العامية The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region. (Chapter 3)

Dialogue list قائمة الحوار A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator. (Chapter 27)

Domestication التوطين Making a translation feel local to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Draft المسودة The first version of a translation. (Chapter 23)

Dubbing الدبلجة Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language. (Chapter 26)

Equivalence التكافؤ A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression. (Chapter 9)

Equivalence (procedure) التكافؤ Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb. (Chapter 12)

Explanatory translation الترجمة الشرحية Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent. (Chapter 13)

Field المجال The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law. (Chapter 17)

Figurative language اللغة المجازية Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect. (Chapter 11)

Fixed expression العبارة المسكوكة A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*. (Chapter 8)

Foreignisation التغريب Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text. (Chapter 13)

Form الشكل The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text. (Chapter 4)

Formal equivalence التكافؤ الشكلي Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb. (Chapter 9)

Free translation الترجمة الحرة Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation. (Chapter 10)

Functional equivalence التكافؤ الوظيفي Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form. (Chapter 9)

Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function. (Chapter 13)

Genre الجنس النصي A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem. (Chapter 17)

Hallucination الهلوسة Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text. (Chapter 22)

Headline العنوان الرئيسي The title of a news story. (Chapter 18)

Homonymy المشترك اللفظي One word with several meanings that are not related. (Chapter 6)

Ideational equivalence التكافؤ الفكري Giving only the basic idea, in plain words. (Chapter 9)

Ideology الأيديولوجيا A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events. (Chapter 19)

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words. (Chapter 8)

Interpreting الترجمة الشفهية Transferring spoken language into another language. (Chapter 1)

Inverted pyramid الهرم المقلوب A news structure that gives the most important facts first. (Chapter 18)

Justification التبرير The reason why a translation choice is right. (Chapter 25)

Lexical creation التوليد المعجمي Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent. (Chapter 16)

Lexical gap الفجوة المعجمية A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other. (Chapter 5)

Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة). (Chapter 10)

Loaded word كلمة مشحونة A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative. (Chapter 19)

Loan translation (calque) النسخ Translating the parts of a compound word one by one. (Chapter 16)

Localisation الأقلمة Adapting a whole product, such as a website, an app or a game, to a local market. (Chapter 22)

Machine translation (MT) الترجمة الآلية Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools. (Chapter 22)

Macro context سياق الموقف (الخارجي) The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text. (Chapter 6)

Meaning المعنى The idea that a form expresses. (Chapter 4)

Mental draft المسودة الذهنية A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text. (Chapter 2)

Metaphor الاستعارة A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning. (Chapter 11)

Micro context (co-text) السياق اللغوي (الداخلي) The words and sentences immediately around a word. (Chapter 6)

Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) الفصحى المعاصرة The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. (Chapter 3)

Modulation التطويع Expressing the same idea from another point of view. (Chapter 12)

Monolingual dictionary معجم أحادي اللغة A dictionary that explains words in the same language. (Chapter 20)

Neologism اللفظ المستحدث A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning. (Chapter 16)

Omission الحذف Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language. (Chapter 13)

Polysemy تعدد المعنى One word with several meanings that are related. (Chapter 6)

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully. (Chapter 22)

Proverb المثل A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth. (Chapter 8)

Register المستوى اللغوي How formal or informal the language is. (Chapter 3)

Revision المراجعة Checking a translation against the source and correcting it. (Chapter 23)

Risk الخطر The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be. (Chapter 24)

Risk management إدارة المخاطر Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm. (Chapter 24)

Risk matrix مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do. (Chapter 24)

Self-initiated translator مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative. (Chapter 1)

Sentence meaning معنى الجملة What the words of a sentence say. (Chapter 5)

Simile التشبيه A comparison that uses “as” or “like”. (Chapter 11)

Skopos theory نظرية الغاية The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated. (Chapter 26)

Source text (ST) النص المصدر The original text that you translate. (Chapter 1)

Speaker meaning مقصد المتكلم What the speaker really means by saying it. (Chapter 5)

Specialised dictionary معجم متخصص A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine. (Chapter 20)

Subtitling الترجمة المرئية / السترجة Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics. (Chapter 27)

Taboo language اللغة المحظورة Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words. (Chapter 27)

Target audience الجمهور المستهدف The people who will read the translation. (Chapter 2)

Target text (TT) النص الهدف Your translation. (Chapter 1)

Term المصطلح A word or expression that names a concept in a special field. (Chapter 21)

Term list قائمة المصطلحات A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations. (Chapter 21)

Termbase (بنك المصطلحات) قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات A database of terms and information about them. (Chapter 21)

Terminologist (خبير المصطلحات) المصطلحي A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes standardises them, in one or more languages. (Chapter 21)

Terminology (المصطلحية) علم المصطلح The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field. (Chapter 21)

Terminology guide دليل المصطلحات A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client. (Chapter 21)

Text النص Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book. (Chapter 17)

Text analysis تحليل النص Breaking down and studying a text before translating it. (Chapter 17)

Text type نمط النص A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade. (Chapter 18)

Tone النبرة The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, friendly, straightforward. (Chapter 17)

Translation الترجمة Transferring meaning from one language into another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting. (Chapter 1)

Translation brief موجز الترجمة The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements. (Chapter 2)

Translation commentary التعليق على الترجمة A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions. (Chapter 25)

Translation memory ذاكرة الترجمة A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse. (Chapter 22)

Translation procedure إجراء الترجمة A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence. (Chapter 12)

Translation strategy استراتيجية الترجمة A planned solution to a translation problem. (Chapter 13)

Transliteration النقل الصوتي Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language. (Chapter 15)

Transposition الإبدال Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb. (Chapter 12)

Verbal sentence الجملة الفعلية A sentence that starts with a verb. (Chapter 3)

Voice-over التعليق الصوتي Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly. (Chapter 26)

Word order ترتيب الكلمات The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence. (Chapter 3)

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“Words travel worlds. Translators do the driving.”

ANNA RUSCONI, TRANSLATOR

A step-by-step guide for complete beginners who want to translate between English and Arabic.

- 27 short chapters, from first steps to subtitling
- Examples in both languages, with exercises and answers
- A glossary of key terms, with their Arabic equivalents



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